

Staff Days — Week 2, Day 7 (Tue Aug 4)

Format note: Still no Joe — he's coming tomorrow. The day was one long line-by-line read of the new behavior policy, then a Guide Platform prototype session, then campus build time. The afternoon tee-up is short.

Housekeeping

0:00–0:07

Feathers compliance. A deep dive found two problems: some guides never did their June feathers at all, and a good percentage **grouped their feathers across their whole guide group instead of going kid by kid**. Both must be remedied by end of day. The point made: insights get watered down the more you aggregate — that's the entire lesson of the DoorDash story. Ten kids, one row each. The Feathers app is locked down because it holds kid data; use the sheet in the guide channel instead, where each campus has a tab and every kid is a row. June entries are already pulled in there.

Aside worth knowing: Steph used **Fable 5 to clone Tom Bennett** (and Carl Hendrick, and Peps) to get expert feedback on the policy when Bennett himself went quiet during contract discussions. It produced four useful tweaks. Same caveat as always — feedback, not gospel, not driving the car.

The Behavior Policy, line by line

0:07–1:51 — led by Samantha DePalo and Matt Shanker

Origin. A small group spent many hours with **Tom Bennett**, a global behavior expert who has worked with thousands of schools. He also spent three days with free rein at Alpha Summer Austin week 1. He came in skeptical — selection effects, rich kids, how could AI teach — and left saying Alpha kids have **more kid-to-adult interaction than any school he's seen, and less screen time**. He shouted out Heidi's real-time classroom management specifically.

Before this, Alpha had **12 different behavior policies for 12 campuses**. This is the first org-wide standard.

The principles

95% persuasion, 5% enforcement. The 95% is the behavior curriculum and boot camp. The 5% is real and it's part of your job — Matt named that many guides last year felt unclear about their role when a boundary got crossed, because guides are optimized to coach.

Enforcement is **fair, firm, consistent** — predictable, not personal. "Clear is kind, unclear is unkind." Consistency means every adult on campus enforces, not just guides, and that the same behavior earns the same consequence at every campus. As students increasingly travel between campuses, that matters.

Warnings, yellows, reds, strikes

- **"Warning" is the term**, org-wide. Miami argued for "heads up," since parents overuse "warning" as an empty threat at home. Decision: warning is the clearest description of the action, and consistency matters more than the label. What actually made it work at Alpha Summer was writing the model down and showing kids on day one.
- **Standard language everywhere:** warning, yellow card, red card, strike. Not lights, not flags.
- **The student must always be told.** It should never be a mystery. Best practice, from NextGen: the student names the behavior and which bucket it falls in, so they own it — "based on your actions, you earned this." With littles, use a visual they can point to. If you're mid-activity and can't have a two-minute dialogue, "hey, that's a warning for XYZ" is fine.
- **Bucket system:** a warning plus a second behavior in the *same* category the same day escalates to a yellow.
- **Warnings reset daily.** Flagged as a risk — a kid could accumulate 50 warnings and zero yellows doing the same thing every day. The reasoning for accepting it: if nothing they do reaches yellow level, nothing they're doing is high risk, so it's worth the generosity for year one. Guide Platform data will show whether that holds.
- **Three red cards = a strike, non-appealable**, to prevent doom loops of endless red card cycles. That kid likely ends up in a Pirate Ship instead.

Strikes, appeals, and expulsion

- One week to appeal. The **strike review team** is the lead guide, head guide, and DOP. **Every strike gets reviewed, and every strike can trigger expulsion review** — the bucket it sits in isn't a ceiling.
- Steph and kids/parents both know everything — no secrets about what's appealable.
- **Open item:** whether there's a cap on appeals per category. Discussed live (one per category? two?) and pinned rather than decided. Commitment made: a policy will exist before anyone hits a repeat appealable strike. Braden noted Austin's appeal template worked well last year and will go org-wide; the appeal is meant to teach the missing skill and be restorative.

- **Violent language** was the most contested section. Words like *kill*, *bomb*, *shoot* are always a strike even in play, but appealable as a learning moment. Braden's real examples: a student saying "I'm gonna kill her" about a nanny, and a student running a game where he announced he was a school shooter. Several people pushed hard on "credible vs. non-credible" as too subjective — it asks every guide to judge intent and capability. Matt is taking suggestions for better wording.
- **Weapons on campus = automatic expulsion review, every time.** Drugs, alcohol, tobacco = strike. The logic is real-world felony lines, plus generosity for the kid who borrowed dad's backpack with Zyns in it. A six-pack in a backpack could still go to expulsion review.
- **Tom Bennett's structural critique:** the original model had a long list of reasons to expel and very little on warnings, yellows, and reds. "Invert your model" — put much more coaching in before defaulting to out. That's why the strike review layer exists.

Consequences, privileges, fines

- **No financial penalty attached to behavior.** Yellows, reds, and strikes never cost Alphas. Fines and fees are a separate thing that students shape in town hall — including deciding to have none.
- Privilege losses are standardized in scope. A red card at the pool costs that day and the next; roughhousing on the playground costs that area for two days. But a red card doesn't cost a full session of off-campus workshops if the workshop is the core of the session.
- Campuses where a privilege maps differently (Plano's rocket ship and comfy seating are the same physical space with very different loss durations) should work it out with their lead or head guide based on how hard the privilege is to earn.

Phones — new org-wide policy

Alpha is a phone-free campus. Kids may bring phones, but from launch until dismissal they cannot be used without specific permission. **Smartwatches are included.** Currently a **yellow card**.

This drew the longest debate. TSA argued for automatic red with no warning — bringing and using a phone is a deliberate choice, and a yellow invites kids to treat a daily warning as an acceptable cost. Scottsdale argued yellow with no warning *after boot camp*. Matt's counterargument for staying generous in year one: a kid who texts an anxious mom three times shouldn't collect a strike while everyone is still learning a brand-new boundary. **No cell phone boxes** — the call is independence and real-world application. Sam also pushed back on phones during Q break, citing Haidt: it destroys exactly the unstructured socialization time that matters.

DOPs own all parent communication about this, not guides. Language is being added to both the first-three-days onboarding doc and the rolling enrollment doc.

Related: **Jonathan Haidt is expected to collaborate with Alpha on middle school socialization.** More to come.

The age-differentiation debate

The most substantive disagreement of the day, and it ran both directions:

- **Scottsdale (middle school):** after boot camp, warnings lower the standard. If a middle schooler has heard the expectation a dozen times, a warning diminishes the process — it should be a straight yellow. **Steph's counter:** a shorter leash requires excellent teaching and measured mastery of the skill first. If you've built a middle school boot camp so good the kids demonstrably don't need warnings, great — **circulate it, because everyone needs it.**
- **Wonder Lab (pre-K):** the opposite. A four-year-old's "skill gap" is genuinely not knowing that words hurt. And losing a privilege the day *after* the incident, when they came in and made good choices, reads as punitive and shameful to a four-year-old. Both the number of warnings *and* which behaviors map to which consequences may need differentiating by age band.

Matt's position on both: this is year one of a standardized model at this scale, it will evolve, and the right move now is to comment directly in the doc rather than fork the policy. **Bryan Gordon has a middle school culture-repair package** that was deployed mid-year to triage a situation — it's being circulated, and the recommendation is every middle school runs it for the first eight weeks.

Smaller items

- Helping someone else cheat should itself count as cheating (Plano) — added as a comment.
- **Roughhousing is a red** because the gap between roughhousing and injury is very short. TSA needs sport-specific "this is in bounds, this is not" language, since bumping in soccer is normal.
- Disrespect has three tiers: minor disrespect (yellow, skill gap or lapse), intentionally hurtful or excessively disrespectful (red), bullying (always a strike). More concrete examples are being added.
- **Posters** explaining the model, standardized and kid-friendly, are wanted but don't exist yet. Some campuses have made them — share in the Pre-K guides channel so they can be standardized.
- A signed parent/student acknowledgment of the policy was suggested and is being passed along.
- **Warning visibility across adults:** the bridge solution is a Guide Platform notification into the campus Slack channel (public, not DMs — transparency won). Ideal state is that it all lives in Guide Platform.

- **Discipline point from Steph:** any time you're about to put student-specific data in Slack, flag it so it can be built into Guide Platform instead. No more hunting across a million sheets, Slack threads, and someone's random app.
 - Google Chat misuse during core skills was raised; Steph is looking at whether to shut it off entirely.
 - **Behavior Support Plans and Pirate Ship** are in the appendix. Trigger points: end-of-session feathers work identifying students the base settings aren't working for, or — for LL specifically — **any LL student getting two red cards in a session** triggers an immediate evaluation. Pirate Ship is the most comprehensive tier.
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Guide Platform prototypes

1:51–3:04 — Alec, in person

Feedback session on the student profile UI before prototypes become real. Changes: left navbar with work units consolidated (a conventional LMS feel, no more tiles), a **60-second handoff summary** for guide transitions, the chatbot as a push-out bar, a built-in tour for new guides, and a to-do list as the first thing you see.

The biggest change: every check now requires an artifact. Students submit proof — the video, the writing, the speech — and it bumps to the guide to confirm and pass. Parents get to see the actual work rather than a sheet of checkboxes. Alpha Check docs load into the student view. Kid view starts at L2 and up.

Requests from the room, mostly about **surfacing signals so guides don't hunt for them:**

- Assign specific checks to a guide or guide group (drop-down), set by the lead guide
- Assign a student two or three checks to focus on this week, on their to-do
- A progress tracker comparing check chart completion against pace through the year
- Auto-flag a student who hasn't progressed a check in ~a week and a half
- Auto-flag a student not earning enough XP to reach 2X, and **a student who hasn't taken a test in X weeks** — the kid quietly hitting 25 XP a day in math for six months without ever testing
- An aggregated, prioritized to-do on the home dash, not buried inside each student profile

Deliberate design line: **no duplication with TimeBack.** Academic data lives in TimeBack; Guide Platform's job is to surface the signal so you know when to go look.

Afternoon build — Alpha Check documents

3:05–3:08

Last week produced the boot camp checks themselves (the "Boot Camp Check Chart All Levels" sheet). Today's job is building the **supporting document for each check** — formerly check-to-pass docs, **now called Alpha Check documents**. Level groups broke into Google Meets, links in the level Slack channels. Use the linked document template so everything stays organized in one shared drive.

Tomorrow

3:11–3:15

Joe is coming to Spyglass in the morning — on his birthday, which he picked himself. He has all the feathers docs including the network roll-up and has already started commenting on the academic items.

He wants to close the loop on feathers: what fixes are actually being implemented. Expect **painfully insightful metrics** to come up — the philosophy behind why student survey questions are yes/no rather than Likert scales, and why the goal isn't questions that make us feel good. He'll likely ask whether any survey questions should change, be added, or be dropped. **There was resounding feedback through the feathers exercise that guides don't like the "school over vacation" question**, so that's the one to be ready to discuss.

Afternoon is open build time for Session 1 deliverables.